



(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Chickenpox

Chickenpox is a common infection that spreads easily and mostly affects children. It usually gets better on its own after 1 to 2 weeks without needing to see a GP, but can be serious in some people.

Symptoms of chickenpox

The main symptom of chickenpox is an itchy, spotty rash. It can be anywhere on the body.

Before or after the rash appears, you might also have:

- a high temperature
- aches and pains, and generally feel unwell
- loss of appetite

Chickenpox happens in 3 stages, but new spots can appear while others are becoming blisters or forming a scab.

Stage 1: small spots appear

The spots can:

- be anywhere on the body, including inside the mouth and around the genitals, which can be painful
- spread or stay in a small area
- be red, pink, darker or the same colour as surrounding skin, depending on your skin tone
- be harder to see on brown and black skin



▼ Long description, image 1

White skin with stage 1 chickenpox spots.

There are 10 spots in different sizes, but they're all less than 1cm. Some spots are close to others. Some spots are raised and appear to be forming a round or slightly oval blister. Other spots are flatter.

The spots are red and pink and the skin around the spots is pink.



Stage 2: the spots become blisters

The spots fill with fluid and become blisters. The blisters are very itchy and may burst.



▼ Long description, image 1

White skin with stage 2 chickenpox spots.

There are 13 spots that vary in size, but they're all less than 1cm. Some spots are close to others. Almost all the spots have formed a round or slightly oval blister. 1 spot looks flatter.

The blisters are pink and shiny. The skin around some spots looks slightly pink.



Stage 3: the blisters become scabs

The spots form a scab. Some scabs are flaky, while others leak fluid.



▼ Long description, image 1

White skin with stage 3 chickenpox spots, blisters and scabs.

There are about 14 spots, which vary in size from around 1mm to 1cm. Some are close together.

Some of the spots look like very small pink blisters. Some are larger, raised and have a scab over them. Some scabs look soft and seem to have fluid under them.

2 of the scabs look like they have collapsed in the centre. The scabs are yellow and pink and the skin around the scabs is pink.



If you're not sure it's chickenpox

Check other rashes in children (Link: www.nhs.uk/symptoms/rashes-babies-and-children/)

How you can treat chickenpox yourself

If you have chickenpox, you'll need to stay off school, nursery or work until all the spots have formed a scab. This is usually 5 days after the spots first appeared.

There are things you can do to treat chickenpox yourself at home without needing to see a GP.

Do

- ✓ drink plenty of fluids (try ice lollies if your child is not drinking)
- ✓ take paracetamol (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/paracetamol-for-children/) to help with any pain and discomfort
- ✓ cut your child's fingernails and put socks on their hands at night to stop them scratching
- ✓ use cooling creams or gels from a pharmacy
- ✓ speak to a pharmacist about using antihistamine medicine (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/antihistamines/) to help itching
- ✓ bathe in cool water and pat the skin dry (do not rub)
- ✓ dress in loose clothes

Don't

- ✗ do not use ibuprofen (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/ibuprofen-for-children/) unless you're told to by a doctor, as it may cause serious skin infections
- ✗ do not give aspirin to children under 16 years
- ✗ do not scratch the spots, as scratching can cause scarring

Important

Do not go near newborn babies or anyone who's pregnant or has a weakened immune system, as chickenpox can be dangerous for them.

See a GP if:

- you're not sure it's chickenpox
- you're concerned about yourself or your child

Tell the receptionist you think it might be chickenpox before going in to a GP surgery.

Get advice from NHS 111 now if:

- your or your child's chickenpox symptoms suddenly get worse
- your child has chickenpox and is showing signs of dehydration (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/dehydration/), such as fewer wet nappies
- the skin around the chickenpox blisters is hot, painful and red (redness may be harder to see on brown or black skin)
- you're breastfeeding and have chickenpox symptoms
- you're pregnant and have not had chickenpox before (or you're not sure) and you've been near someone with chickenpox
- you have a weakened immune system and have been near someone with chickenpox
- you think your newborn baby has chickenpox or has been near someone with chickenpox

Some people may be able to take medicine to prevent complications. It needs to be started within 24 hours of the spots appearing.

You can call 111 or get help from 111 online (Link: <https://111.nhs.uk/triage/check-your-symptoms>). Call 111 if you need advice for a child under 5 years old.

How chickenpox is spread

You can spread chickenpox to other people from 2 days before your spots appear until they have all formed scabs, which is usually 5 days after your spots appeared.

The spots start appearing around 1 to 3 weeks after you caught chickenpox.

You can catch chickenpox from:

- being in the same room as someone with it
- touching things that have fluid from the blisters on them
- someone who has shingles (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/shingles/) if you have not had chickenpox before (but you cannot catch shingles from someone who has chickenpox)

The chickenpox vaccine

Children are now offered the MMRV vaccine (Link: www.nhs.uk/vaccinations/mmr-vaccine/), which protects against measles, mumps, rubella and chickenpox (varicella).

They are offered 2 doses of the vaccine when they are 12 months and 18 months old. Older children born on or after 1 January 2020 are also offered 1 or 2 doses of the vaccine.

You may also be offered the chickenpox vaccine (Link: www.nhs.uk/vaccinations/chickenpox-vaccine/) on the NHS if there's a risk you could spread the virus to someone who has a weakened immune system.

For example, you can be vaccinated if you're living with someone who is having chemotherapy.

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